

CONNOTATIONS

The feelings and ideas a word suggests



1 What is it?

Connotations (kon-oh-TAY-shuns)

A connotation is the **feeling or idea** a word suggests beyond its literal dictionary meaning — the same fact can feel very different depending on the word chosen.

word choice = hidden feeling

2 See it in action

Same meaning, different feel

"Slim" sounds like a compliment;
"skinny" can sound like a criticism.

Describing a home

"Cosy flat" feels warm;
"cramped flat" feels unpleasant.

Describing a leader

"Confident" feels positive;
"arrogant" feels negative.

In headlines

Calling a crowd a "mob"
(negative) vs a "gathering"
(neutral).



Good spot!

Try swapping the word for a **synonym** with a similar dictionary meaning — if the feeling changes, you've found connotation in action.

FUN FACT

Advertisers spend huge amounts of money researching connotations — that's why perfume names sound like "Eternity" or "Obsession" rather than just "Perfume #4."

3 Why writers use it

Connotations help writers: shape how the reader feels about a person, place or event WITHOUT saying it directly — connotation is how writers (and journalists, and advertisers) quietly steer opinion through word choice alone.

Two writers can describe the exact same event using entirely factual, "true" words — and still make the reader feel completely different things, just by picking words with different connotations.

4 Where you'll spot it

News headlines

The same event gets called a "riot" or an "uprising" depending on the newspaper's viewpoint.

Product marketing

Brands choose words like "artisan" or "premium" purely for their positive connotations.



Watch out!

Don't confuse connotation with denotation! **Denotation** is a word's literal dictionary definition; **connotation** is the extra feeling it carries. Always analyse both.



Keep going!

When analysing word choice, always ask: "**what did the writer want me to FEEL, not just know?**" That's the heart of connotation analysis.

5 Quick recap

The feeling behind a word

Beyond the literal meaning

Shapes the reader's opinion



Mfalme says...

Practise rewriting one neutral sentence with positive connotations, then again with negative ones — same facts, totally different impression.